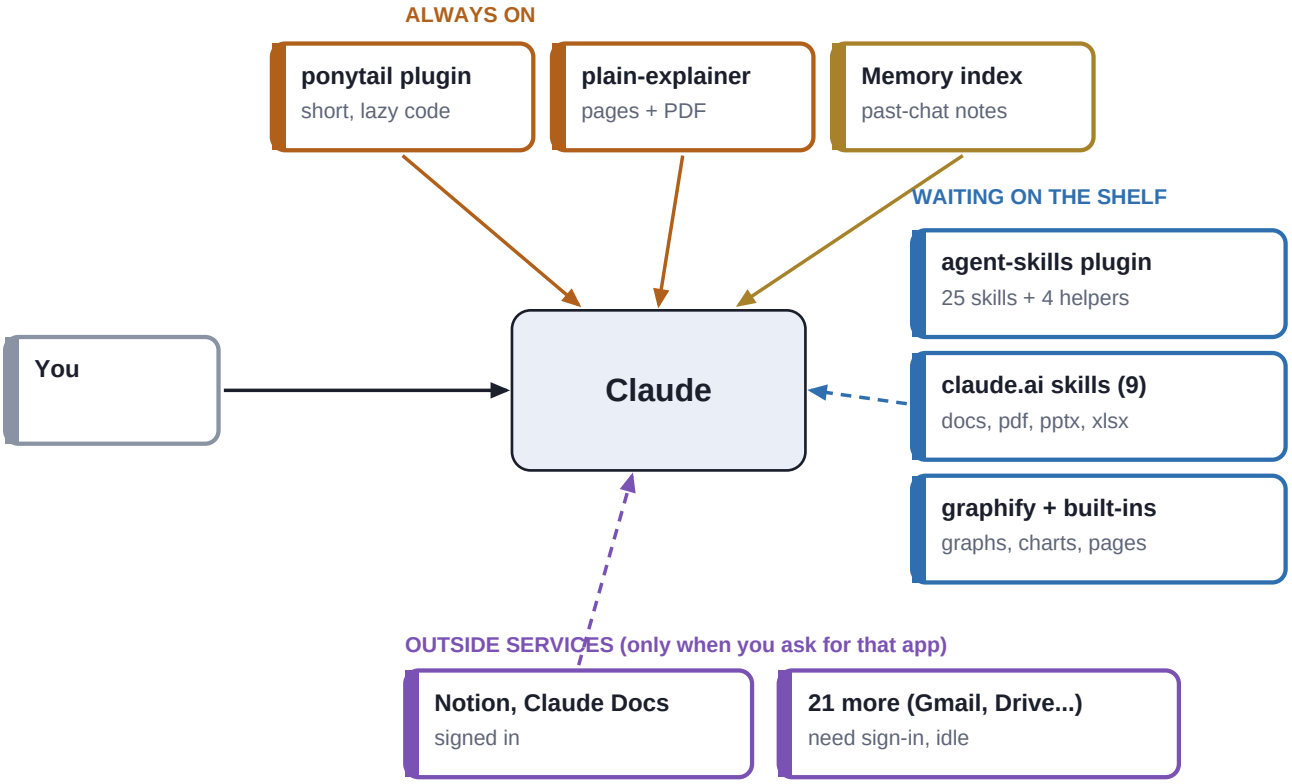
What your plugins and skills do

Only three things change **every** answer: the **ponytail** plugin, your **plain-explainer** rule and your **memory notes**. Everything else waits on a shelf and costs almost nothing until a task needs it.

A **skill** is a written recipe Claude can follow, like a checklist in a binder. A **plugin** is a bundle someone else made that can hold skills, helpers and small automatic scripts (**hooks**, which run by themselves at set moments). Claude reads the binder's table of contents every message, but opens a recipe only when your request fits it.



Amber items ride along with every message. Blue items are only a line in the table of contents until a task matches. Violet services are touched only when you ask for that app.

What you have, counted

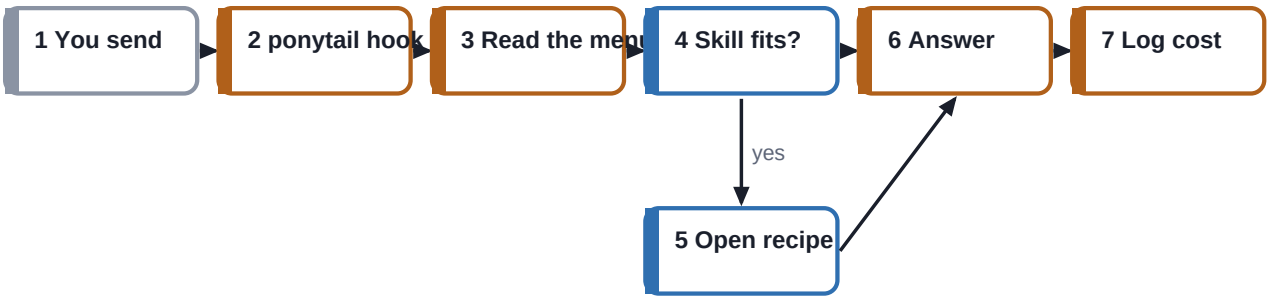
Item	From	Contains	When it runs
ponytail 5.3.3	Plugin, installed today	6 skills, 3 hooks, a cost log	Always
agent-skills 0.6.15	Plugin, installed today	25 skills, 4 helper reviewers, 9 commands	On match
plain-explainer	Your skill + global rule	1 recipe	Every explanation
graphify	Your skill	1 large recipe	Only on /graphify
claude.ai skills	Your claude.ai account	9: docs, docx, pdf, pptx, xlsx, Google files, morning brief, memory import, skill maker	On match
Built-in skills	Claude Code	About 17 (pages, charts, code review, settings...)	On match
Connectors	claude.ai account	2 signed in, 21 waiting for sign-in	When asked
Memory index	Notes for this project	19 lines, about 11,000 characters	Always

IF YOU REMEMBER ONE THING

Installing many skills is cheap. What really matters is the few items that run on every message.

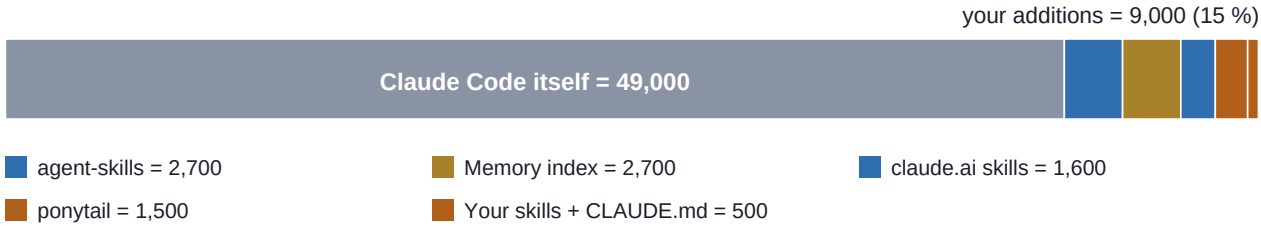
What happens with every message

Each time you press Enter, Claude first reads a 'menu': its own rules, the list of every skill, and your memory notes. Your plugins and skills make that menu about **15 % longer**.



Steps 2 and 7 are ponytail's automatic scripts (hooks). Step 5 happens only when your request fits a skill.

How big is the menu?



Measured on your first message today: 58,138 tokens in, 1,136 out, logged by ponytail as about $0.22 at pay-as-you-go prices. Tokens are small word pieces; 1 token is about 4 characters. After the first message the menu is mostly re-used from a cache (short-term memory on the server), billed at a fraction of the normal price.

When a recipe is opened

Recipe	Extra tokens, once	Plus the answer it makes
graphify	about 10,500	A knowledge graph of your files: large
plain-explainer	about 1,200	Several pages + a PDF: the largest output in your setup
ponytail	about 900	Shorter code than usual: saves output
A typical agent-skills recipe	about 3,500	Depends on the task

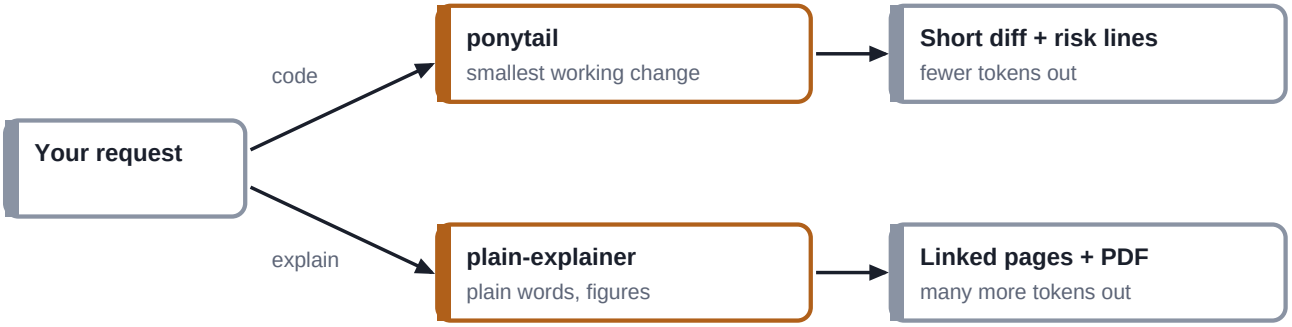
Helpers (the 4 reviewer agents) are the expensive case: each one is a separate Claude that reads its own menu and files.

IF YOU REMEMBER ONE THING

The menu costs a little on every message; a skill costs more only when opened; the answer it makes is usually the biggest part.

What each one does to your answers

ponytail and plain-explainer pull in **opposite directions**: the least code versus rich pages. They rarely clash, because one is about code and the other about explanations.



Item	Effect you will notice	Side effects
ponytail	Code changes as small as possible; each reply ends with what was skipped and any risk. /ponytail lite, full, ultra; 'stop ponytail'.	Also puts every helper agent in ponytail mode. Writes a cost row per message to ~/.config/ponytail/band/.
plain-explainer	Every explanation becomes linked pages, a PDF in deliverables/ and a PowerPoint question.	The slowest and most token-heavy habit you have.
Memory index	I remember past results, links and pending decisions.	Long (about 2,700 tokens): each line carries many dates and version notes.
agent-skills	Step-by-step recipes for planning, testing, debugging, security, specs, reviews.	Overlaps: three ways to review code, two to simplify. Its hook scripts are present but not switched on.
graphify	Map of how your files relate, only on /graphify.	Large recipe; nothing until called.
claude.ai skills	Word, PDF, PowerPoint, Excel, Google files, Docs, morning brief.	None until used.
Connectors	Notion and Claude Docs ready; 21 others need sign-in on claude.ai.	Idle ones cost nothing.

IF YOU REMEMBER ONE THING

ponytail and plain-explainer change how answers look. The rest only act when you ask for their job.

What you can change

You do not need to remove anything to save money. The two changes that help most are a **shorter memory index** and using **plain-explainer only when you will share the result**.

A and B together cut the menu by about 4,600 tokens per message (8 %). C saves on answers instead and is usually the bigger saving.

Decisions for you

	Question	Recommendation
A	Shorten the memory index?	Yes: one short line per topic, history moved into the topic files. Saves about 1,900 tokens per message.
B	Keep agent-skills?	This project is data analysis; most of its 25 recipes are for building software. Switch off with /plugin, back on when you build an app. Saves about 2,700 per message.
C	plain-explainer always, or only when asked?	Chat by default; pages + PDF when you say 'for sharing'.
D	ponytail cost log?	Costs no tokens. Keep it to track spending; turn 'ledger' off in its settings if not.

Where to change it

Plugins: /plugin (or 'enabledPlugins' in ~/.claude/settings.json) · plain-explainer rule: ~/.claude/CLAUDE.md · Memory: ask me to shorten MEMORY.md · Real usage: /cost (pay-as-you-go), /status (plan). On a Pro, Max or Team plan none of this costs extra money; it only uses up your usage limit sooner.

IF YOU REMEMBER ONE THING

The biggest saving is not removing plugins. It is a shorter memory index and fewer full page-and-PDF answers.